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THE POWER APPS BUILDER'S GUIDE FOR CHOOSING THE RIGHT PATH

Where each option shines and how to choose

April Dunnam | Principal Cloud Advocate, Microsoft

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MEET YOUR SPEAKER

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THE ORIGINAL PROMISE

“Everyone can be an app builder.”

AI is making it real in new ways.

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The decision used to be simple

Canvas app

- Custom UI, pixel by pixel
- Power Fx formulas
- Full layout control

Model-driven app

- Data-first, on Dataverse
- Structure, forms, views & rules
- Consistent, responsive UI for free

Then things changed…

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The app landscape has grown

POWER PLATFORM

Governed in the Power Platform admin center (PPAC)

- Canvas apps
- Model-driven + generative pages
- Code apps
- PCF components

COPILOT MANAGED RUNTIME

Preview · Microsoft 365 admin center

- Apps in Copilot Studio
- Copilot Cowork apps
- Copilot Code

Bridge: your apps inside Microsoft 365 Copilot via the Power Apps MCP server

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TODAY'S CHAPTERS

Agenda

I **The Paths**
What each path is and who owns it

II **Building in the Real World**
Four big rocks, four live demos

III **The Elephant in the Room**
Low code, AI & your existing apps

IV **Choosing Your Path**
Three questions, trade-offs & licensing

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CHAPTER I

The Paths

What each path is and who inherits it later

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Meet the paths (1 of 2)

PROMPT-TO-APP

Apps in Copilot Studio · Preview

Prompt-to-app: a generated, code-based app on the Copilot Managed Runtime

For makers & business users

CUSTOM UI, LOW CODE

Canvas apps

Maker-owned UI: forms, mobile & frontline, Power Fx

For makers

AI-ASSISTED CANVAS

Canvas + coding agents · GA

.pa.yaml + Power Fx generated from your prompts

For makers using VS Code / GitHub Copilot CLI

DATA-FIRST

Model-driven apps

Dataverse-first: forms, views, roles, rules, with Copilot & app skills built in

For makers & configurators

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Meet the paths (2 of 2)

AI-GENERATED PAGES

Generative pages

React pages inside an existing model-driven app

For code-aware makers & developers

APPS IN COPILOT CHAT

Power Apps in Microsoft 365 Copilot

Your app’s data & actions in Copilot chat and agents (MCP)

For Copilot-first users

PRO-CODE

Code apps

Full-code React/Vue apps, hosted on Power Platform

For developers & code-aware makers

REUSABLE CONTROLS

PCF

Reusable field & grid controls

For developers

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Two homes, in detail

Power Platform

HOME 1

- Canvas, model-driven + generative pages, code apps, PCF
- Dataverse, solutions, ALM, Managed Environments
- Governed in the Power Platform admin center
- Licensed via Power Apps (Premium)

Copilot Managed Runtime

HOME 2 · PREVIEW

- Apps from Copilot Studio, Copilot Cowork, Copilot Code & the SDK
- Microsoft-hosted · Entra auth · 1,500+ connectors · Git
- Governed in the Microsoft 365 admin center
- Copilot Credits · Power Apps Premium users run apps without credits

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Plot twist: what's retiring

NEW HOMES FOR APP CREATION

SEP 8, 2026

Apps in Copilot Cowork (Frontier)

SEP 25, 2026

Copilot Managed Runtime · Preview

EARLY OCT 2026

Apps in Copilot Studio · Preview

RETIRING

MID-OCT 2026

New app creation blocked in Vibe & App Builder

NOV 30, 2026

vibe.powerapps.com & the App Builder agent retire

Migration = rebuild from source, not a move.

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CHAPTER II

Building in the Real World

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ROCK 1 OF 4

Canvas apps

Coding agents, the in-studio agent and what canvas still does best

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AI-assisted canvas

Canvas apps authored with AI coding agents · GA

01	**Status**	GA since Sep 1, 2026 · in-studio agent: Preview
02	**Output**	.pa.yaml + Power Fx in a standard canvas app
03	**Mechanism**	The Canvas Authoring MCP server validates the code and live-syncs it into Studio coauthoring
04	**Prereqs**	.NET 10 SDK · GitHub Copilot CLI, Claude Code or VS Code · an existing saved app with coauthoring on
05	**Install**	`/plugin marketplace add microsoft/power-platform-skills` `/plugin install canvas-apps@power-platform-skills`

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DEMO

Canvas + GitHub Copilot CLI

GA · natural language → .pa.yaml → live sync into Studio

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What you just saw

1

Maker typed

A natural-language request

2

Power Apps got

.pa.yaml, controls, Power Fx, validation and live Studio sync

3

Maker owns

A finished app in Studio, same governance & ALM

Best use: scaffold faster. Not best use: outsourcing validation.

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In-studio canvas agent

Agentic authoring inside canvas studio · Preview

01	**Status**	Preview since Oct 27, 2026 · announced at PPCC 2026
02	**What it does**	Plans first, then builds screens, controls and Power Fx in the open app
03	**How it works**	You describe the app, approve the plan, then refine by prompt or by hand. It stays a standard canvas app
04	**Prereqs**	An admin enables the tenant setting in the Power Platform admin center · a GitHub account, which GitHub bills for usage
05	**Limits**	US only · English only · review the plan and the app before you share it

Canvas is not dead

1

Still powerful

Forms, tasks, mobile & frontline, Power Fx on modern controls & the modern data grid

2

No longer alone

For truly custom UI, Copilot Studio apps and code apps are realistic options

3

The real shift

AI lowers the barrier to code, and your Power Fx debugging skills transfer

New rule: guide dev tools. Don't avoid them.

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ROCK 2 OF 4

Model-driven apps

Generative pages, PCF with coding agents, and apps in Copilot chat

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Generative pages

Coding agents

RECOMMENDED

- GitHub Copilot CLI or Claude Code + the model-apps plugin (/genpage)
- Worldwide on public clouds
- Multiple pages + tables in one run

In the browser

MAKE.POWERAPPS.COM

- MDA designer → Add page → Describe a page
- US, Great Britain, Australia & Singapore only
- US English prompts · up to 6 Dataverse tables

GA since Nov 2025 · connectors & custom APIs in Preview · no extra credits

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DEMO

Model-driven app + Generative pages

Add page → Describe a page → iterate

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PCF with coding agents

Lower the barrier to custom controls · pcf plugin: Preview

01	**Status**	pcf plugin in power-platform-skills · Preview since Oct 2026
02	**What it does**	Scaffolds, builds, tests, deploys and verifies controls
03	**Why it matters**	Templates and quality gates guide the agent, so a code-aware maker can ship a control, not only a pro developer
04	**Prereqs**	Node.js 20+ and npm · PAC CLI to deploy · .NET SDK to package · Azure CLI to verify
05	**Install**	`/plugin marketplace add microsoft/power-platform-skills` `/plugin install pcf@power-platform-skills`

Generative page or PCF?

1

Standard forms & views

Configure forms and views first, then reach for code when they fall short

2

Generative pages

A richer page for one scenario inside an existing MDA

3

PCF

A reusable field or grid control, easier to build with the pcf plugin (Preview)

Coding agents lower the barrier to PCF, but gen pages don't replace every PCF control.

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Apps in Copilot chat

Your apps inside Microsoft 365 Copilot

01 **Enable your app in Microsoft Copilot · Preview, model-driven**
Generates an MCP server + declarative agent, so grids & forms show up in Copilot chat

02 **Extend it**
Add custom tools and MCP Apps widgets

03 **Agent feed + Power Apps MCP server · GA (May 2026)**
Agents work inside your app and hand off to humans

04 **The message**
No rebuild: the app becomes a capability layer, not just a destination

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DEMO

Power Apps in Microsoft 365 Copilot

Preview · enable the app in Microsoft Copilot → ask → update

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ROCK 3 OF 4

Code apps

The pro-code path, hosted and governed on Power Platform

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Code apps: the pro-code path

What it is

Full-code React/Vue apps in any IDE, hosted & governed on Power Platform, with 1,500+ connectors, Dataverse and flows. GA since Feb 2026.

BUILD IT

```
npm i -g @microsoft/power-apps-cli
pa app init → pa app run
npm run build → pa app push
```

…or let GitHub Copilot drive with the code-apps plugin

Who it’s for

Dev teams and code-aware makers with complex UX needs. End users need Power Apps Premium.

NOT YET

- Power Platform Git integration
- Power Apps for Windows
- SharePoint forms

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The GitHub Copilot app

A maker-friendly front door to building with code

01 **Desktop app · GA June 2026 · Windows, macOS & Linux**
Works with any GitHub Copilot plan: a visual workspace instead of a terminal

02 **Describe it, steer it**
Each session runs in its own isolated workspace, so you can run several in parallel

03 **Built-in validation loop**
See diffs, preview in the in-app browser, run checks, then merge

04 **Bring your Power Platform tools**
MCP servers, plugins & skills, e.g. microsoft/power-platform-skills

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ROCK 4 OF 4

Copilot Managed Runtime

Where you build these apps, and what changes for admins

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Four entry points, one runtime

BUSINESS USERS

Copilot Cowork · Frontier

Describe the app in chat or use the /app skill, then preview and publish

For people who want to keep working

MAKERS · PREVIEW

Apps in Copilot Studio

Build apps alongside agents and workflows from a described idea

For makers solving a whole process

BUILD YOUR OWN

Copilot Code

Build apps and code in Copilot, powered by the same technology as GitHub Copilot

For knowledge workers who build

DEVELOPERS

SDK and CLI

Bring your own tooling and land on the same governed runtime

For professional developers

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PROMPT-TO-APP · PREVIEW

Apps in Copilot Studio

- Preview · rolling out from early October 2026
- New experience → Apps → describe it, answer clarifying questions, review the plan
- Iterate with chat, files, screenshots & annotations
- Generated code app. The code view is read-only; change it by describing
- Data: SharePoint lists, Dataverse tables, sample data. Runs as the signed-in user
- Runs on Copilot Managed Runtime; building uses Copilot Credits

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DEMO

Apps in Copilot Studio

Preview · describe → clarify → plan → generate → publish

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Dataverse plugin for Cowork

One prompt to a governed Dataverse app in Copilot Cowork

01	**Status**	Available in Copilot Cowork · announced at PPCC 2026
02	**Builds**	Tables, relationships, business logic, sample data and a published app
03	**Governance**	You approve every change, and every action runs under your own permissions
04	**Also in**	GitHub Copilot, Claude Code, Codex, Cursor, Gemini CLI and n8n use the same open-source Dataverse skills
05	**Install**	`Cowork: Customize > Microsoft Dataverse > Connect` `Copilot CLI: /plugin install dataverse@awesome-copilot`

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Why Copilot Managed Runtime matters

1

A new home

Copilot Managed Runtime apps are governed in the Microsoft 365 admin center, not PPAC

2

New owners & billing

Different admins, app inventory and Copilot Credits than your Power Platform CoE

3

A new way to edit

Code is read-only. Makers change apps by prompting, not in Studio

Before you build, ask: which admin center, and which team, owns this app?

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What to use when

BIG ROCK	I NEED…	REACH FOR
CANVAS	Custom UI, forms, mobile, maker-edited	Canvas app
	Build or change a canvas app faster	Coding or in-studio agent
MODEL-DRIVEN	Data-first app with roles and rules	Model-driven app
	One richer page in an existing MDA	Generative page
	A reusable field or grid control	PCF + pcf plugin
	Your MDA inside Copilot chat	Enable in Microsoft Copilot
CODE APPS	Custom UX, dev-owned, platform-governed	Code app
COPILOT MANAGED RUNTIME	Fast team app from a prompt	Copilot Studio or Cowork app

Pick by need first, then check who will maintain it and where it is governed

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CHAPTER III

The Elephant in the Room

Is there still “low code" and what happens to my apps?

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Is there really “low code” anymore?

Where AI struggles

- Drag-and-drop designers
- Proprietary app metadata
- Visual logic that’s hard to diff

Where AI shines

- React, TypeScript & Python
- Text in, text out: diffs & Git
- Agents test & self-correct

So the new tools write code, even when you never see it.

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What this means for makers

1

Low code → low effort

You describe the intent and agents write the code, but the code is still there

2

Your skills move up

Data modeling, requirements, testing & governance beat control placement

3

Review is the job

Read diffs, test, and own what ships. Someone maintains it for years

Low code isn't dead: the code just moved behind the prompt.

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When traditional Power Apps still wins

01	Rich Dataverse business logic	→ Model-driven: security roles, business process flows, auditing
02	Offline & frontline mobile	→ Canvas apps in Power Apps mobile, with offline support
03	Makers must keep editing it	→ Canvas: editable Power Fx in Studio, not prompt-only read-only code
04	Enterprise ALM across environments	→ Solutions, pipelines & Managed Environments in PPAC

Copilot Studio apps for speed. Power Apps for depth, control & longevity.

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What about my existing apps?

01	Canvas apps in production	→ Keep them: modern controls; add screens with coding agents
02	Vibe or App Builder apps	→ Rebuild from source in Apps in Copilot Studio before Nov 30, 2026
03	Model-driven apps	→ Extend: generative pages + enable in Microsoft Copilot
04	Canvas apps that outgrew Power Fx	→ Rebuild as a code app with GitHub Copilot, same connectors & data

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CHAPTER IV

Choosing Your Path

Three questions. Answer honestly. The path picks itself.

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Q1 · Who builds and maintains it?

01	Business user / no-code	→ Apps in Copilot Studio or Copilot Cowork
02	Maker	→ Canvas or model-driven
03	AI-augmented maker	→ Canvas / generative pages with coding agents (VS Code, GitHub Copilot CLI)
04	Developer	→ Code apps (+ PCF)

New maker skill tree: VS Code, GitHub Copilot, prompts, diffs, errors, reviews.

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Q2 · Where do users encounter it?

1

Full-screen app

Canvas, model-driven, code app or Copilot Studio app

2

Inside an existing MDA

Generative page

3

In Microsoft 365 Copilot

App enabled in Microsoft Copilot / Power Apps MCP server

Don’t build a destination when users need a capability.

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Q3 · How complex? How long-lived?

01	Quick POC / personal or team tool	→ Copilot Studio app
02	Team tool, maker-owned	→ Canvas or model-driven (coding agents speed the build)
03	Custom UI inside an MDA	→ Generative pages
04	Enterprise UX, dev team, PPAC ALM	→ Code apps

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Where Fabric and vibe coding fit

FABRIC APPS

Preview · Fabric admin portal

- Rayfin SDK, TypeScript
- Semantic model + SQL connectors
- Entra sign-in, Fabric permissions
- Hosted in a Fabric workspace

VIBE CODING YOUR OWN STACK

Claude Code, GitHub Copilot, Cursor

- You own hosting, auth and ALM
- Great for prototypes and products
- Or ship it as a Power Platform code app

Rule of thumb: business apps in Power Platform, data apps in Fabric, product code in your stack

Which app option fits?

Home

POWER PLATFORM

MANAGED RUNTIME

FABRIC

YOUR STACK

Option	Built with	Best for	Governed in	Data
Canvas + model-driven	Low code, Power Fx, Dataverse-first	Forms, mobile, frontline apps	Power Platform admin center	Dataverse + 1,500+ connectors
Code apps	React or Vue in your own editor	Custom UI with platform governance	Power Platform admin center	Dataverse + connectors
Copilot Managed Runtime Preview	A prompt in Copilot Studio or Cowork	Fast team apps with no setup	Microsoft 365 admin center	1,500+ connectors
Fabric Apps Preview	Rayfin SDK in TypeScript	Apps on analytics data	Fabric admin portal	Semantic models + SQL
Vibe code your own stack	Claude Code, GitHub Copilot, Cursor	Products with full freedom	Your own hosting, auth, ALM	Whatever you wire up

More freedom, more you own

Rule of thumb: business apps in Power Platform, data apps in Fabric, product code in your own stack

What it costs and how it's billed

Home

- POWER PLATFORM
- MANAGED RUNTIME
- FABRIC
- YOUR STACK

Option	To build	To run	Billed as	Heads up
Canvas + model-driven	Canvas: no license. Model-driven: Premium	Premium, or Microsoft 365 if standard connectors only	$20 per user a month, or $10 per active user per app	Premium goes to $22 in Jan 2027
Code apps	Premium, plus a license for your coding tool	Premium for every end user	$20 per user a month, plus your coding tool plan	Microsoft 365 rights are not enough
Copilot Managed Runtime Preview	Cowork: Copilot license plus credits. Studio: credits	Premium or Copilot Credits	Credits: 0.1 per API call. Premium covers daily limits	Microsoft 365 rights do not cover running
Fabric Apps Preview	A Fabric workspace with capacity	Access to the app item in Fabric	Fabric capacity units, no separate Rayfin charge	SQL, GraphQL and OneLake use capacity
Vibe code your own stack	Your tool subscription: Claude, GitHub Copilot, Cursor	Whatever you host it on	Tool plans plus your own hosting bill	You own auth, hosting and the bill

More freedom, more you own

Seats for people who run apps, credits for AI and agents, capacity for Fabric

The framework in action

1

HR expense tracker

Maker team · long-lived · many data integrations

→ Canvas app: a coding agent speeds the build

2

Sales wants accounts in Copilot

A model-driven app already exists

→ Enable the MDA in Microsoft Copilot, no rebuild

3

Field equipment checkout

Team tool · needed fast · SharePoint data

→ App in Copilot Studio

Bonus: a benefits portal with complex UX and a dev team → code app

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The honest maintainability table

PATH	HOME & GOVERNANCE	WHO MAINTAINS IT	HONEST WATCH-OUT
Apps in Copilot Studio	Copilot Managed Runtime · M365 admin center	Maker via prompts	Preview; code is read-only; Copilot Credits from build time
Canvas apps	Power Platform · PPAC	Maker / Power Fx	Don’t force the UI. Know when to go code
Canvas + coding agents	Power Platform · PPAC	Same maker, in Studio	GA; still needs validation & human review
Model-driven + generative pages	Power Platform · PPAC	Maker + TS-aware help	Browser path region-limited; React/TS knowledge helps
Code apps	Power Platform · PPAC	Developer	It’s code, so someone must read, review and debug it
PCF components	Power Platform · PPAC	Developer	Know when you need a component vs a page or app

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Takeaways

01 Canvas isn't "dead" - embrace coding agents to develop them

02 Vibe & App Builder → Apps in Copilot Studio & Copilot Cowork

03 Ask three questions: maintainer, surface, lifespan

04 AI is great at code, so makers now own, review & govern what it builds

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Keep building: resources

- **Agent Academy**
  aka.ms/agent-academy
- **Apps in Copilot Studio**
  learn.microsoft.com/microsoft-copilot-studio/apps-experience/apps-overview
- **Generative pages**
  aka.ms/genpages-docs
- **Canvas AI code-gen tools**
  aka.ms/canvas-coding-tools
- **Code apps**
  aka.ms/codeapps-docs
- **Power Platform skills plugins**
  github.com/microsoft/power-platform-skills
- **April on YouTube**
  youtube.com/@aprildunnam

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THANK YOU!

Go build on the right path. Questions?

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